

Leave Policy

Decoding Data Science (DDS) — People & Culture

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This policy defines all leave entitlements at DDS, how leave accrues, how to request it, and how requests are approved. It replaces Leave Policy v1 (March 2026) in full. Where UAE Federal Decree-Law No. 33 of 2021 (the UAE Labour Law) provides a greater benefit, the law prevails.

Note: this is a synthetic, training-friendly policy created for demos, onboarding simulations, and HR-chatbot prototypes. It is not legal advice.

1. Leave Entitlements at a Glance

Leave type	Entitlement	Pay	Minimum notice	Evidence required
Annual leave	22 working days per year	Full pay	7 calendar days (see §3.4)	None
Sick leave	15 working days per year at full pay	Full pay (then per §4.4)	Same day, within 1 hour of start time	Medical certificate for 2+ consecutive days
Maternity leave	60 calendar days	Full pay	30 calendar days before expected date	Medical documentation
Paternity leave	5 working days, within 6 months of birth	Full pay	30 calendar days where foreseeable	Birth certificate
Parental leave (additional)	5 working days per parent, within 6 months of birth	Full pay	14 calendar days	Birth certificate
Bereavement leave	5 working days (spouse/child/parent); 3 working days (sibling/grandparent)	Full pay	Notify as soon as possible	May be requested
Marriage leave	3 working days (once during employment)	Full pay	14 calendar days	Marriage certificate
Study leave	10 working days per year (2+ years of service, enrolled at an accredited UAE institution)	Full pay	14 calendar days	Exam schedule / enrollment proof
Hajj leave	Up to 30 calendar days (once during employment)	Unpaid	60 calendar days	None
Unpaid leave	Up to 30 calendar days per year, case-by-case	Unpaid	30 calendar days	Manager + HR approval
Public holidays	Per the official UAE calendar	Full pay	Not applicable	Not deducted from annual leave

2. Definitions

- **Leave year:** 1 January to 31 December.
- **Working day:** Monday to Friday, excluding UAE public holidays.
- **Calendar day:** any day, including weekends and public holidays.
- **Immediate family:** spouse, child, or parent.

- **Leave system:** the DDS HR portal where all leave is requested, approved, and tracked.

3. Annual Leave

3.1 Entitlement

Full-time employees are entitled to **22 working days** of paid annual leave per leave year. Part-time employees receive a pro-rata entitlement based on contracted hours. Employees who join or leave mid-year receive a pro-rata entitlement for that year.

3.2 Accrual

Annual leave accrues at **1.83 working days per completed calendar month** of service. During the probation period, leave accrues normally; accrued days may be used during probation with line-manager approval.

3.3 Booking limits

- The maximum single block of annual leave is **15 consecutive working days**. Longer blocks require CEO approval.
- At least **5 of the 22 days** must be taken as one continuous block of 5 working days each year, to support genuine rest.
- Leave may be taken in half-day units at minimum.

3.4 Notice periods for annual leave requests

Length of leave requested	Minimum notice before start date
1–2 working days	7 calendar days
3–9 working days	14 calendar days
10 or more working days	30 calendar days

Managers respond to leave requests within **3 business days**. Employees should not book non-refundable travel before approval is confirmed in the leave system.

3.5 Peak periods

During flagship delivery windows (major bootcamps, the annual conference season, and product launches), approvals may be restricted. HR publishes restricted weeks at the start of each quarter. Requests in restricted weeks require Head-of-Department approval.

4. Carry-Over, Expiry and Encashment

4.1 Carry-over

A maximum of **10 unused annual-leave days** may be carried into the next leave year. Carry-over is automatic; no approval is needed.

4.2 Expiry

Carried-over days must be used by **31 March** (end of Q1) of the new leave year. Any carried-over days not used by 31 March **expire without compensation**.

4.3 Encashment

Unused annual leave is **not** paid out during employment. On termination of employment, accrued but unused annual leave for the current year is paid out at the employee's basic salary rate, in line with UAE Labour Law.

5. Sick Leave

5.1 Entitlement

Employees receive **15 working days of fully paid sick leave** per leave year, available after completion of the probation period.

5.2 Notification

- Notify your line manager **within 1 hour of your normal start time** on the first day of absence (message or call).
- Log the absence in the leave system on the day of return, or earlier if able.

5.3 Medical certificates

A medical certificate from a licensed practitioner is required for any absence of **2 or more consecutive working days**, and may be requested for shorter or repeated absences where a pattern suggests misuse.

5.4 Extended illness

If an illness continues beyond the 15 fully paid days, additional sick leave follows the UAE Labour Law structure within the same leave year: up to **30 further calendar days at half pay**, then up to **45 further calendar days unpaid**, subject to medical documentation. HR manages extended-illness cases confidentially with the employee.

5.5 Partial working

If an employee is unwell but able to work reduced hours, this may be agreed with the line manager. Health always takes priority; nobody is expected to work while genuinely unwell.

6. Public Holidays

- DDS observes the official **UAE public-holiday calendar** for Dubai-based employees. HR publishes the calendar each January.
- Public holidays are paid and are **not deducted** from the annual-leave balance.
- If a public holiday falls within an approved period of annual leave, that day is **not counted** as an annual-leave day.
- Employees contracted outside the UAE observe the public holidays of their contract location.
- Where business-critical operations (live events, launches) require work on a public holiday, the employee receives a **substitute day off in lieu**, to be taken within 60 days.

7. Maternity, Paternity and Parental Leave

7.1 Maternity leave

- **60 calendar days at full pay**. This exceeds the UAE statutory minimum as an enhanced DDS benefit.
- Notify HR at least **30 calendar days** before the expected date of leave, with medical documentation.
- Leave may begin up to 30 days before the expected delivery date.
- An additional period of up to **45 calendar days unpaid** may be taken for medical reasons related to the pregnancy or delivery, with a medical certificate.

7.2 Nursing breaks

For **6 months following return** from maternity leave, the employee is entitled to one paid nursing break of **1 hour per day**, scheduled flexibly with the line manager.

7.3 Paternity leave

Fathers receive **5 working days at full pay**, to be taken within **6 months** of the child's birth, consecutively or split. Provide notice 30 calendar days ahead where foreseeable.

7.4 Parental leave (additional)

In addition to maternity/paternity leave, each parent may take **5 working days of paid parental leave** within 6 months of the birth, in line with UAE Labour Law.

7.5 Adoption

Employees adopting a child under the age of 5 receive the same entitlements as in §7.1–7.4, measured from the date of placement.

7.6 Return to work

Managers must agree a written transition plan before leave begins and a re-onboarding plan for the return. Returning parents come back to the same role or an equivalent role on the same terms.

8. Other Leave Types

8.1 Bereavement (compassionate) leave

5 working days at full pay for the death of a spouse, child, or parent; **3 working days at full pay** for the death of a sibling, grandparent, or grandchild. Notify your manager as soon as possible; documentation may be requested. Additional unpaid leave may be approved case-by-case.

8.2 Marriage leave

3 working days at full pay, once during employment, taken within 30 days of the marriage. Provide 14 calendar days' notice and a marriage certificate.

8.3 Study and exam leave

Employees with **2 or more years of service** who are enrolled at an accredited UAE educational institution receive **10 working days of paid study leave per year** for examinations, per UAE Labour Law. Provide the exam schedule 14 calendar days ahead.

8.4 Hajj leave

Muslim employees may take **up to 30 calendar days of unpaid leave once during their employment** to perform Hajj. Request 60 calendar days in advance so coverage can be planned.

8.5 Unpaid leave

- Up to **30 calendar days per leave year**, approved case-by-case by the line manager and HR.
- Annual leave must be exhausted first unless HR agrees otherwise.
- Unpaid leave may affect payroll, benefits accrual, and visa arrangements; HR will confirm the impact in writing before approval.

9. Religious Observance and Ramadan Working Hours

- During Ramadan, daily working hours are **reduced by 2 hours** for all employees, per UAE regulation.
- Teams schedule meetings considerably around fasting and prayer times.
- Additional flexibility (shifted hours, remote days) can be agreed with the line manager where the role allows.

10. How to Request Leave (Workflow)

Step	Action	Owner	Timing
1	Submit the request in the leave system with dates, leave type, and a short coverage plan (deliverables, who covers, key deadlines).	Employee	Per the notice table in §3.4
2	Review and approve/decline with a reason.	Line manager	Within 3 business days
3	Compliance check for balance, carry-over expiry, and restricted weeks.	HR	Automatic in the leave system
4	Notify affected stakeholders and hand over client-facing commitments.	Employee	Before leave starts
5	Emergency leave: notify your manager immediately by any channel, then submit the request retroactively.	Employee	Within 48 hours

Approved leave appears in the shared team calendar. Cancelling approved leave restores the days to the employee's balance automatically.

11. Misuse and Compliance

- Misrepresenting sickness, falsifying certificates, or working a second job while on sick leave are treated as misconduct under the DDS Disciplinary Policy.
- DDS may request documentation where reasonable and lawful.
- Managers may not pressure employees to cancel or shorten approved leave except in genuine business emergencies, and any such case must be reported to HR.

12. Governance

- **Policy owner:** Head of People & Culture, DDS.
- **Review cycle:** annually, each June, or earlier if UAE labour regulations change.
- **Precedence:** where an employment contract or UAE Labour Law grants a greater benefit, that provision prevails over this policy.
- **Questions:** contact People & Culture via the HR portal, or ask DecoBot, the DDS HR assistant.

Version history — v1.0 (March 2026): initial synthetic policy. v2.0 (July 2026): full rewrite with fixed entitlements, notice tables, carry-over and expiry rules, extended parental provisions, and workflow SLAs.